JAIPUR
***VIKAS DWIVEDI, 70**
*Retired Inspector General of Police (*name changed)*

The con: **Aadhaar linked to child trafficking racket**
Sum lost: **Rs 2.16 crore**
(Rs 1.7 crore recovered)

"They made me a prisoner in my home"

It began with a WhatsApp call that the retired IGP answered absentmindedly on an August morning. The voice on the other end was professional, almost courteous. "Sir, this is Mumbai Customs," the caller said. "A package linked to your Aadhaar has been detained. It's critical we verify your details immediately."

Vikas, who had once served with the United Nations, didn't flinch. He offered his Aadhaar details, casually mentioning that he had lost his cellphone a month earlier and filed an FIR. "Oh sir. That explains it," the caller said. "Someone must have accessed your data from that phone. Please hold as I escalate this to the CBI."

Before Vikas could respond, he was transferred to another line. The sound of a wireless set filled the background. A sharp, commanding voice cut through. "Arrest this man immediately! His name has come up in a drug trafficking case. Fake passports and ATM cards in his name were recovered in a raid."

Vikas froze. Before he could process the information, a video call popped up on his screen. The man on the other side wore a crisp white shirt, the emblem of the CBI prominently displayed behind him. His expression was grave.

The scammers are a mix of local operators, international fraud networks and 'cyber slaves', or victims of human trafficking

THE MODUS OPERANDI

Methodically planned and executed, these digital stings exploit the victims' worst fears in a country where the process itself is known to be the punishment. It begins with a call, usually from a masked number or from a location in a major city, often New Delhi or Mumbai. To evade detection, criminals procure multiple SIM cards from different mobile network operators. These SIM cards are used through SIM box technology to bypass official international gateways, routing international calls—often originating in Southeast Asian countries—via Voice over Internet Protocol (VoIP) systems to give the appearance of it being a local call. The callers introduce themselves as being from a courier service or a government organisation, their tone initially neutral, to build rapport. Then, they make a startling accusation—money-laundering, drug or human trafficking, crimes serious enough to evoke immediate fear.

By the time they are told that their Aadhaar or PAN info is tangled with the crime, the victims are already on edge. Like the retired police officer in Indore who was told his phone number had surfaced in a case of drug trafficking. As a former law enforcer himself, he understood the gravity of the charge. The scammers played on his fears further, convincing him to transfer Rs 1 crore to "clear his name". In the case of Rabia Thakur, a 23-year-old Bengaluru-based techie, the scammers posed as "Lucknow police, Customs Information Centre", calling to inform her that a FedEx parcel in her name sent from Lucknow to Cambodia carried multiple passports and ATM cards.

Once the initial contact is made and the charges specified, the fraud escalates over the next few days. Victims are asked to join a video call, where the scene is set with remarkable attention to detail. Rabia was asked to download Skype for interrogation. "There were three men on the other side of the video call," she said in her complaint to the police. "They said I needed to record my statement and share my details. They also mentioned that there is an arrest warrant in my name related to human trafficking and money-laundering." Posing as officers of central investigation agencies such as the CBI and ED or the drug enforcement agency, Narcotics Control Bureau, or even the Supreme Court, the scammers leverage advanced technologies such as deepfake videos blended with 'social engineering' tools to create an incredibly convincing façade of authenticity. In the case of Oswal, the scammers were able to pass themselves off as CJI Chandrachud conducting a fake Supreme Court hearing over Skype. Many victims are informed that they are under "digital arrest", a fake coinage that has no basis in law. They're told that to protect their families from embarrassment, it's imperative they stay under surveillance until the "investigation" concludes. Isolation is critical in this process; the scammers forbid the victim from contacting family or friends, tightening their psychological hold.

A good bit of digital snooping has typically preceded this scenario creation, or what's called in the world of cyber con as the 'pretext' stage. Scammers use the Aadhaar details or social media posts to prepare a psycho-social